FOCUS

Disinformation and elections: resisting without making the problem worse

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IN BRIEF

- **Disinformation shifts few votes.** Where its direct effect has been measured, it is very small, although it remains uncertain in very close contests.
- **That does not make it harmless.** It can discourage people from voting, smear a candidate at the last minute, cast doubt on accurate information and supply pretexts for contesting a result. These indirect effects are better documented than the effect on vote choice.
- **Sweeping, alarmist talk about interference makes the problem worse.** Saying, without further detail, that "the election is being targeted by interference" is not necessarily false, since interference attempts do exist. The difficulty lies in what the public concludes from it: people overestimate the effect of these operations on the vote and may end up attributing the result to them, forgetting that millions of voters genuinely made a choice. The legitimacy of that choice is weakened, trust in the election and in information declines, and that is often precisely what the interference was after.
- **Action is therefore needed, but it must be precise.** That means explaining concretely how the vote is protected, making documented cases public rather than the threat in general, correcting specific content and working through messengers the public trusts.
- **All of this requires a restraint from candidates that cannot be taken for granted.** Each of them, acting alone, may stand to gain from crying interference or fraud. Hence the need for collective campaign discipline, and for vigilance towards those who denounce interference in terms that serve it.

WHO CAN DO WHAT

Candidates and parties — Actions 1–4

DO

- ✓ Denounce interference by citing a specific, documented case.
- ✓ Prepare the response to a *deepfake* before it arrives.

AVOID

- × Contest a result without evidence.
- × Say "I am the target of interference" without saying which.

Citizens — Actions 5–7

DO

- ✓ Check the source rather than suspect everything.
- ✓ Find out in advance how the vote is protected.

AVOID

- × Pass on general alerts about *deepfakes*.

Media and fact-checkers — Actions 8–10

DO

- ✓ Correct quickly, precisely and completely.
- ✓ Check the origin of suspicious content before reporting on it.

AVOID

- × Put a fake seen by a few thousand people on the front page.

Institutions — Actions 11–14

DO

- ✓ Explain concretely, and in advance, how the vote is protected.
- ✓ Work through trusted messengers, as close to the ground as possible.
- ✓ Prepare for after the vote as much as for the campaign.

AVOID

- × Sound the alarm with no specific case to show.

The fourteen actions are set out in full below, under "What everyone can do".

In 2024, more than half of humanity was called to the polls, and many predicted that generative AI would decide the outcomes. It did nothing of the sort. In Europe, observers counted fewer than thirty viral cases, and none had a demonstrated effect on any result (Stockwell, 2024; Simon and Altay, 2025). The episode is instructive because it repeats a pattern that researchers know well. Each election brings its own technique of deception, a wave of concern and a series of countermeasures, and then, once the dust has settled, little evidence that any voter was persuaded of anything. This Focus starts from that gap between fear and evidence, and draws out what it implies for action.

Disinformation can harm an election through three channels of unequal importance. The first, and the most feared, is persuasion. For false content to swing an election, it would have to reach voters who are still undecided, they would have to believe it, and they would then have to change their vote because of it. Each of these steps is hard to clear, because most people see little disinformation, and those who consume a lot of it are already convinced. That is why the direct effect, where it has been measured, is very small. It would nonetheless be unwise to rule it out in an election decided by a few thousand votes.

The second channel requires no one to be persuaded. A false claim can deter voters from turning out, smear a candidate too late for them to respond, sow doubt about accurate information or hand arguments to those who want to contest the result. These indirect effects are less visible than the effect on vote choice, but they are better documented, so that judging disinformation solely by its power to convince leads us to underestimate its cost.

The third channel is the least intuitive, and it strikes us as the most important: part of the damage stems from the way we react. Foreign interference does not seek only to help a candidate win. Analysis of the Russian operations of 2016 shows that they also aimed to divide public opinion and to discourage some voters from going to the polls (DiResta et al., 2019), and casting doubt on the election itself is, more broadly, among the aims of operations of this kind. It follows that sweeping, alarmist talk about interference can, on its own, produce the very effect the attacker was seeking.

The mechanism is easy to grasp from statements that have become familiar, such as those of a candidate who claims to be "the target of interference" without saying what kind, or of a minister who keeps repeating that "the election is being targeted by foreign powers". Such statements are not necessarily false, since interference attempts are real. The problem lies in what the public takes away from them. Without learning that a specific operation has been detected and contained, people come to believe that the vote may have been distorted. They then tend to overestimate the effect of interference on behaviour and to attribute the result to it, instead of seeing it as the genuine choice of voters, so that it is the legitimacy of that democratic choice that suffers, and trust in the election along with it. The absence of specific cases compounds the damage: since nothing is cited, nothing can be checked, and suspicion, lacking any object, spreads until it reaches reliable media as well. A news outlet that splashes a fake seen by a few thousand people across its front page arrives at a similar result by another route, that of disproportion, since it gives a marginal incident the stature of a national threat. The reaction, whether it comes from the politician or from the outlet, thus hands the attacker a success that the operation alone would probably not have achieved.

This mechanism has been established experimentally in only one specific case, that of claims that interference has swayed the vote (see box 3). For vaguer warnings, along the lines of "the election is being targeted", we are extrapolating from those results. The hypothesis is plausible, but it has not yet been measured as such, and we offer it for what it is.

None of this means that disinformation is harmless, or that silence is the better course. The lesson, rather, is that action must be precise, and that care must be taken not to pile alarm upon alarm. In practice, the right response is to explain how the vote is protected and to make specific, documented cases public: which operation, carried out by whom, reaching how many people, and what was done in response. A report of this kind gives the public evidence it can check and judge for itself, whereas a general alert worries people without showing them anything. Resisting disinformation at election time therefore means pursuing two tasks at once, the second of which is the harder: protecting the vote, and making sure that our reactions do not worsen the harm they claim to fight.

WHAT AN ELECTION CHANGES

An election is a stress test for the information ecosystem. For a few weeks, public attention is at its peak, political identities are mobilised and the outcome is often close. Above all, time is short, and false information released the day before the vote can no longer be corrected in time.

At the same time, responding becomes riskier, because the actors under pressure to react (candidates, media, institutions) are also the ones who can do the most damage if they react badly. We therefore propose judging each measure by its **net effect**, that is, by how much it reduces belief in what is false, minus how much it reduces trust in what is true. A good measure pushes back falsehood without eroding what is true. A bad measure may also push back falsehood, but it casts doubt on what is true along the way, to the point that its overall balance can turn negative. This criterion guides all the recommendations that follow, and it places the burden of proof on the response as much as on the threat.

What disinformation does to an election

Before choosing a response, we need to understand how disinformation actually works during a campaign. The boxes that follow first examine its direct effect on the vote, which is small where it has been measured but uncertain in close elections, and then its indirect effects, which are less visible and better documented. The last box brings together two kinds of damage that come not from the attacker itself but from actors in public debate: politicians contesting results, which is the best-demonstrated harm, and alarmist responses, which can serve the very attacker they claim to fight.

1. A small but uncertain direct effect

The most widespread fear is that of the manipulated voter, who sees false content, believes it and changes their vote accordingly. The studies paint a very different picture. To change a vote, false content has to clear three successive hurdles, and each one sharply reduces its chances of success.

1

Reach the voter

Disinformation makes up a small share of what people consume online.

→

2

Be believed

Those who see it most already agree with it; it rarely wins over new audiences.

→

3

Change the vote

Even campaign persuasion barely manages this.

1.3% This is the median share of disinformation in what internet users consume online, measured from their browsing data (review of 443 studies). In France, unreliable sites account for 0.16% of time spent online (Altay, 2026; Cordonier and Brest, 2021).

70% This is the median share of disinformation-related activity (visits, exposures, shares) that comes from just 1% of users (Altay, 2026). In the United States, these heavy consumers are mostly older, conservative and highly interested in politics (Grinberg et al., 2019; Guess, Nagler and Tucker, 2019). Disinformation is therefore mainly the business of a small minority.

- **Mass persuasion is hard.** A synthesis of 49 field experiments shows that campaign contact and advertising have virtually no effect on vote choice in US general elections (Kalla and Broockman, 2018). If organised, well-funded persuasion achieves so little, it is hard to see how false content, seen by far fewer people, could do much better.
- **The Russian example of 2016.** On Twitter, accounts run by the Internet Research Agency, the Russian "troll factory", mainly reached Republicans who were already convinced, and no measurable effect of this exposure on their opinions or their vote was found (Eady et al., 2023).
- **The public is less gullible than is often assumed.** Its most common error is not so much believing what is false as doubting what is true (Pfänder and Altay, 2025). This finding bears on everything that follows, because a response that increases general distrust makes precisely this most common error worse.

Doubt must nonetheless be stated as doubt. Current methods struggle to capture slow or cumulative effects that build up over years, and absence of evidence is not evidence of absence. When an election is decided by a few thousand votes, even a small effect can matter.

2. Better-documented indirect effects

Disinformation does not need to convince in order to do harm. Those who produce it are often after something other than persuasion, and the cases and experiments below show that these other channels are, for the most part, better established than the effect on vote choice.

Discouraging people from voting

False information about the date of the vote, the polling station to go to or the documents to bring targets turnout rather than opinion. It seeks to keep voters at home, which is easier than winning them over (Darcy, 2026), and the mechanism requires no persuasion at all.

Striking when it is too late to correct

In Slovakia in 2023, a fake audio recording was released during the 48-hour moratorium before the vote, a period in which candidates are no longer allowed to campaign. Fact-checkers debunked it the same day, but the moratorium limited the targeted candidate's ability to respond, and the recording kept circulating, notably on Telegram and Facebook. We do not know whether it changed the result. What the case does show is where the real danger lies in a campaign, namely the lack of time for the facts to catch up with the rumour (de Nadal and Jančárik, 2024).

Smearing a candidate's reputation

A *deepfake* is a realistic fake video made with AI. In several experiments, a *deepfake* lowered support for the targeted candidate, even though participants found it less credible than a real video. Studies disagree, however, on what a fact-check published afterwards can achieve. According to some, it sharply reduces the damage (Dan, 2025). According to others, it makes the video less credible, but the harm to the candidate persists for several days before fading (Hameleers et al., 2026). In other words, a correction undermines the video's credibility faster than it restores the candidate's reputation.

The "liar's dividend"

The more the public knows that evidence can be fabricated, the easier it becomes to dismiss authentic evidence. A politician caught up in a real scandal can then simply reply "it's a fake". In the United States, five experiments involving more than 15,000 adults show that this defence helps politicians retain more support than an apology or silence would. It works against written evidence, much less against video, and a fact-check is enough to wipe out the gain (Schiff, Schiff and Bueno, 2025).

Dividing and muddying the waters

Some campaigns seek less to impose an idea than to inflame tensions. In 2016, the same Russian operators ran both fake Black activist accounts and fake ultra-conservative pages, to stoke anger on both sides (DiResta et al., 2019). Other operations put out multiple contradictory versions of the same event, as if the goal were for the public to conclude that nothing can be trusted. This muddying has practical consequences, since experiments show that exposure to conspiracy content reduces the intention to vote (Jolley and Douglas, 2014).

3. When the damage comes from within: contested results and alarmist responses

The two kinds of damage grouped here have one thing in common: they originate with legitimate actors in public debate (politicians, governments, media), whose words carry much further than those of an anonymous attacker. It is on this side, moreover, that the best-demonstrated harm lies.

Contesting the results

Contesting a result without evidence is the best-demonstrated harm. Around the 2020 US election, one experiment exposed participants to statements by Donald Trump calling the vote into question, and these statements lowered his supporters' trust in elections (Clayton et al., 2021). The damage is all the more serious because it is hard to repair: another experiment, conducted after the 2018 midterm elections, shows that denials by major media outlets do not measurably reduce it (Berlinski et al., 2023).

Those who contest a result also pay a price. After the November 2020 presidential election, Donald Trump claimed without evidence that the vote had been stolen from him, in the State of Georgia among other places. In the Senate runoff held there in January 2021, turnout fell more in the precincts where he was most popular and, at the individual level, turnout among his supporters fell by about **1.7 points** more than among other voters:

some of them, discouraged by the idea that the vote was rigged, appear to have stayed at home. In the December 2022 Senate runoff, this drop was smaller (Fraga, Peskowitz and Szewczyk, 2025). A survey of Georgia voters points in the same direction: those who doubted the integrity of the 2020 election were less likely to vote in January 2021, especially in Trump's camp (McKee, Hood and Pittman, 2026). This delayed cost, borne by the challenger's own camp, will play a part in our conclusion.

The alarmism trap

The second kind of damage is more paradoxical, because it arises from the wish to protect. Information interference often seeks to make people doubt the election itself, whether its fairness, its result or the point of voting at all. Yet sweeping, alarmist talk ("our elections are being manipulated", "disinformation threatens democracy") produces exactly that doubt. It thus does the attacker's work for them, and can hand them a success that their operation alone would probably not have achieved. The diagram below breaks this sequence down.

How alarm does the attacker's work

1. **An interference operation** is launched. On its own, it reaches few people.
2. **A general alarm** amplifies it ("the election is being targeted"), without citing any specific case.
3. **The public overestimates its effect** and attributes the result to interference rather than to the choice of voters.
4. **Trust falls** in the election and in information, and the attacker achieves its goal.

Two real episodes illustrate the difference between alarm and precise reporting. They do not amount to a measured comparison, but they show how the mechanism can play out.

When alarm wins out: United States, 2016

No investigation established that Russia had altered the vote count, and no measurable effect of its fake Twitter accounts on opinions was found (Eady et al., 2023). *Yet in December 2016, after weeks of coverage of "Russian interference", 52% of Democrats believed it was true that Russia had "tampered with vote tallies" to get Donald Trump elected* (Economist/YouGov poll). *The figure also reflects the usual reaction of the losing side, but it shows how easily real but limited interference can come to be seen as decisive.*

- A real operation, but with limited effect
- An effect overestimated to the point of casting doubt on the result itself

Precise reporting: United States, 2018

On the eve of the midterm elections, Facebook announced that, following a tip-off from the authorities, it had blocked 115 Facebook and Instagram accounts suspected of links to a foreign actor. On election day, a website claiming to speak for the Russian "troll factory" asserted that it had influenced the election. The US authorities later stated that there was no evidence that any foreign actor had been able to alter the vote count (US Treasury, 2019).

- Dated, quantified facts
- A claim by the attacker, whose aim is precisely to make people believe in its influence
- A response that states what was affected, and what was not

Several experiments make it possible to test the links in this chain one by one.

- **Announcing that interference influenced the vote lowers trust in the result.** In the United States, participants read an article stating with certainty that Russian disinformation had influenced the 2016 election. Afterwards, they believed that other voters had been influenced, and it was through this belief that both their confidence in the result and their satisfaction with democracy fell, even when the article condemned the foreign actor. The message "they tried to manipulate us" thus turns into "others were manipulated, so the vote was distorted" (Ross, Vaccari and Chadwick, 2022).
- **Alarm encourages restrictions on free speech.** In the United States, readers exposed to an alarmist article about disinformation were more supportive of restrictions on online speech. In the same study, the people who feel most threatened by disinformation are also the least satisfied with democracy, although it is unclear which causes which (Jungherr and Rauchfleisch, 2024). Alarm, which presents itself as a defence of public debate, can therefore end up curbing it.
- **Talking about the threat does not reassure.** In Canada, participants read either a message focused on the threat of interference or a message explaining how the vote is protected. Only the second strengthened their trust in elections. The first improved nothing, even though its purpose was to warn people in order to protect them (Bordeleau and Garnett, 2024).
- **General warnings make people doubt what is true.** Warning the public that *deepfakes* exist does not help them spot one; mostly, people start judging authentic videos to be fake (Ternovski, Kalla and Aronow, 2022). Similarly, the most common interventions (fact-checks, tips on staying vigilant, articles about disinformation) reduce belief in false information but also make accurate information less credible (Hoes et al., 2024). Suspicion therefore does not stop at what is false; it spills over onto everything else.

These findings do not imply that one should stay silent or play down real operations. Rather, they argue for replacing general alarm with two more useful things. The first is a **specific policy**, setting out who does what and with what resources. The second is the **reporting of specific cases**, stating which operation was carried out, by whom, reaching how many people, and what was done in response. A documented case gives the public verifiable evidence and contains the threat, instead of leaving it hanging over the whole election. This distinction, it should be stressed, has not yet been tested as such: it extends the findings above, which concern claims that interference affected the vote and general warnings. Nor does it remove every cost, since, as we have just seen, even fact-checks can make accurate information less credible. Precision therefore reduces the risk without eliminating it, which is why each intervention should be judged on its net effect.

A systemic phenomenon

The effects described in these three boxes sustain one another, and that is what makes the phenomenon systemic. Distrust makes disinformation more credible; disinformation, and the alarm surrounding it, increase distrust; and poorly calibrated responses feed the scepticism they set out to cure. Because these effects reinforce each other and unfold over time, it is hard to isolate the specific contribution of disinformation, which is one more reason not to judge its seriousness solely by its direct effect on the vote.

Main sources: Altay, 2026 · Kalla and Broockman, *APSR*, 2018 · Eady et al., *Nature Communications*, 2023 · Clayton et al., *PNAS*, 2021 · Fraga, Peskowitz and Szewczyk, *Political Behavior*, 2025 · Van Duyn and Collier, 2019 · Schiff, Schiff and Bueno, *APSR*, 2025 · Berlinski et al., 2023 · Ross, Vaccari and Chadwick, 2022 · Ternovski, Kalla and Aronow, 2022 · Jungherr and Rauchfleisch, 2024 · Bordeleau and Garnett, 2024 · Hoes et al., 2024.

What everyone can do

No tool is enough on its own, and even the best-evaluated ones have modest effects that fade over time. Research nonetheless makes it possible to tell what helps from what harms, with a degree of certainty that varies and that the final table specifies for each practice. All the actions proposed here apply the net-effect criterion defined earlier: a measure is worthwhile only if it pushes back falsehood without casting doubt on what is true.

This criterion calls for changing four reflexes that recur from one actor to the next:

INSTEAD OF…	PREFER…
Warning about the threat	→ **Explaining the safeguards of the vote**
Facts that are explained strengthen trust; a warning on its own does not.	
Sounding a general alarm	→ **Reporting specific, documented cases**
A specific case can be checked; a vague alarm lets suspicion spread to the whole election.	
Learning to suspect everything	→ **Learning to recognise what is reliable**
Generalised distrust also casts doubt on accurate information.	
Counting on an information campaign	→ **Relying on trusted local messengers**
Institutional messages struggle to reach distrustful voters.	

The fourteen actions that follow are grouped by actor, because candidates, citizens, media and institutions have neither the same levers nor the same temptations, and because the actors best placed to cause harm are often those who are supposed to prevent it.

CANDIDATES AND PARTIES: FIRST, DO NOT MAKE THINGS WORSE

1. **Never contest a result without evidence.**
   - **Why:** this is the best-demonstrated harm. A candidate who contests a result lowers, first and foremost, their own voters' trust in elections (Clayton et al., 2021).
   - **What they lose:** some of those voters abstain at the next election (Fraga, Peskowitz and Szewczyk, 2025).

2 Do not cry “fake news” in response to a well-founded accusation.

- **Why:** the tactic can pay off in the short term, but it carries a collective cost. Politicians' talk of “fake news” lowers trust in the media and people's ability to recognise genuine news (Van Duyn and Collier, 2019). Used in response to a specific scandal, however, this defence does not appear to reduce general trust in the media (Schiff, Schiff and Bueno, 2025), which suggests that the collective cost comes mainly from repeated use of the tactic.
- **Instead:** in the face of a real scandal, acknowledge the facts and apologise. Crying fake may admittedly yield more in the short term (Schiff, Schiff and Bueno, 2025), but a fact-check is enough to wipe out that gain, and other experiments show that apologies work better than evasion or silence (Clementson, Zhao and Beatty, 2024). Recommending an apology therefore amounts to asking candidates to forgo a possible gain for the sake of the common interest, which foreshadows the dilemma discussed in the conclusion.

3 Do not invoke interference in general terms.

- **Avoid:** “I am the target of foreign interference”, “this election is being targeted by interference”, without saying what kind.
- **Why:** voters can neither check nor defend themselves. All they take away is that the result may be distorted, which is precisely what many interference operations are after. Such statements are also sometimes used to discredit a defeat or legitimate criticism in advance.
- **Instead:** pass the specific case on to the competent authorities, with the evidence available, and leave it to them to establish it publicly. In France, these authorities include Viginum, the government agency responsible for detecting foreign digital interference, and the National Commission for the Control of the Electoral Campaign, which ensures that the rules are respected during the presidential election.

4 Prepare the response to a *deepfake* before it arrives.

- **In practice:** have authenticated official channels, keep the originals of one's own videos, and line up in advance independent fact-checkers able to respond within a few hours.
- **Why a third party:** a correction is more effective when it comes from a source the target audience finds credible, which will often be an independent third party rather than the candidate. It is also more effective when it explains why the content is false and what actually happened (Ecker et al., 2022).

CITIZENS: RECOGNISE WHAT IS RELIABLE RATHER THAN HUNT FOR WHAT IS FALSE

5 Learn to check the source, rather than to suspect everything.

- **The method:** “lateral reading” means leaving the page to look elsewhere for who is behind a piece of information. In a randomised classroom trial, it clearly improved US high school students' ability to judge the credibility of a source (Wineburg et al., 2022).
- **The habit:** following news outlets on social media also improves knowledge and trust (Altay, Hoes and Wojcieszak, 2025).

6 Find out in advance how the vote is protected.

- **The principle:** this is known as **prebunking**. Knowing the safeguards of the vote in advance helps people recognise false information when it appears, instead of waiting for it to be corrected.
- **The result:** in the United States and Brazil, a message explaining the safeguards of the vote strengthened trust, and did so more durably than a correction.
- **What works:** the facts being explained, not the warning about the threat (Carey et al., 2025).

7 Do not pass on general alerts about *deepfakes*.

- **Why:** they do not help people spot fakes, and they make people doubt real videos (Ternovski, Kalla and Aronow, 2022).
- **Instead:** check where a video comes from. Who published it first? Has a reliable source picked it up?

MEDIA AND FACT-CHECKERS: COVER IN PROPORTION

8 Give disinformation the space it actually occupies, and remind audiences of the safeguards of the vote.

- **Framing matters:** in Canada, an article explaining how the vote is protected strengthened readers' trust, which an article presenting interference as a threat did not (Bordeleau and Garnett, 2024).
- **The risk of amplification:** a **deepfake** seen by a few thousand people, if it becomes a national story, reaches through the media an audience its authors would never have reached on their own. This risk is inferred from research on amplification, but it has not been measured directly.

9 Correct quickly, precisely and completely.

- **What works:** a “disputed” label on a specific piece of content.
- **What harms:** a general warning such as “beware, false information is circulating”, which also makes people doubt true information (Clayton et al., 2020).
- **Caution:** labelling only some false content makes the rest more credible (Pennycook et al., 2020).
- **The limits:** fact-checking corrects beliefs without changing support for the candidate (Nyhan et al., 2020), and it reaches few of the most exposed, since almost no readers of a dubious site read the corresponding fact-check (Guess, Nyhan and Reifler, 2020).
- **Under attack:** when a politician wrongly accuses a media outlet of spreading “fake news”, the outlet should respond, because its reply strengthens its credibility (Neo, 2022).

10 Check the origin of suspicious content before reporting on it.

- Do not rebroadcast the clip, even to denounce it.
- Trace it back to the original source and examine the file's technical data.
- Agree in advance with the electoral authorities on how to work together in an emergency.

INSTITUTIONS: EXPLAIN THE SAFEGUARDS, SPEAK SOBERLY, PREPARE FOR AFTER THE VOTE

11 **Explain, concretely and in advance, all the integrity safeguards that actually exist.** This is the lever best supported by experiments, provided it reaches distrustful voters (see the next action).

- **What:** who counts the ballots, who oversees the count, how a result is verified, why it sometimes takes time.
- **The result:** in an experiment in the United States with nearly 8,500 participants, 30-second videos featuring election officials from both parties strengthened the trust of Democrats and Republicans alike (Gaudette et al., 2025). Another video, explaining why the count can take a long time, largely offset the distrust that a late result tends to provoke (Lockhart et al., 2024).
- **A rare advantage:** unlike alarm, this message exaggerates nothing, since the safeguards it describes are real.
- **The limit:** its effect seems to fade quickly, so it has to be repeated.

12 **Have the message carried by trusted people, as close to the ground as possible.**

- **Why:** messages that work in surveys reach distrustful people poorly in real life. In the Houston area, in Texas, an information campaign targeting some 148,000 conservative voters judged likely to be sceptical improved neither their general trust in elections nor their turnout during the 2024 presidential election (Kousser et al., 2026). Relying on local messengers has not yet been tested as such.
- **In France, for example:** a mayor, a polling station assessor appointed by another candidate (assessors are citizens who staff the polling station) or a regional newspaper will probably be listened to more than government communication. The regional daily press is considered trustworthy by 63% of French people (La Croix-Verian, 2026).

13 **Report specific cases rather than sound the alarm.**

- **When necessary:** make a documented foreign operation public, with specific facts (who, what, on what scale, what response), without dramatising.
- **Why not alarm:** a general alert spreads doubt over the entire election, which is just what the attacker wants, without giving the public any means of checking.
- **For regulation:** rules should target account authenticity and transparency (who is speaking, who is paying), not confer a power to decide what is true.

14 **Prepare for after the vote as much as for the campaign.**

- Telling voters that the results have been audited strengthens their trust.
- How the audit is conducted and presented matters more than what it finds, as long as the discrepancies found remain small (Jaffe et al., 2023).

Good and bad practices at a glance

The table sets out, actor by actor, what research recommends, what it advises against and what the studies show. The level of evidence is rated **solid** (several converging studies), **moderate** (one or two good studies), **weak** (case studies or a single country) or **untested**. Where results diverge, we distinguish experiments (survey-based, under controlled conditions) from real life (actual campaigns, with actual voters). The distinction is more than a formality, because a practice that looks promising in experiments, such as explaining the safeguards of the vote, can lose most of its effect in the field.

Actor	Good practice	Bad practice	What the studies show
Candidates	Accept the election result, and contest it only on the basis of solid evidence.	Allege fraud without evidence, before or after the vote.	Supporters of a candidate who contests the result lose trust in elections, and some of them abstain at the next election, which costs that candidate's own camp votes. Solid
Candidates	In the face of a well-founded accusation, acknowledge the facts and apologise.	Dismiss an accurate accusation as "fake news".	This defence can help retain support in the short term, especially against written evidence, but a fact-check is enough to wipe out its benefit. More broadly, politicians' talk of "fake news" lowers trust in the media. Solid for the short-term effect, moderate for the collective cost
Candidates	Report a specific case of interference to the competent authorities, with the evidence available.	Declare "I am the target of interference" or "the election is being targeted", without saying what kind.	When the public reads that interference has swayed the vote, it judges the result less legitimate, even if the message condemns the foreign actor. The effect of vaguer warnings has not been measured directly. Moderate
Candidates	Prepare the response to a *deepfake* before the campaign: authenticated channels, an archive of one's own videos, independent fact-checkers ready to step in.	Improvise a response when the time comes, or stay silent in the hope that it will blow over.	A fact-check published by a credible third party reduces the harm caused by a *deepfake*, sometimes sharply, but not always straight away. To our knowledge, the effect of silence has not been measured. Moderate
Citizens	Learn to check who is behind a piece of information, and follow reliable news media.	Learn above all to distrust everything one reads.	Learning to recognise reliable sources improves judgement. Conversely, learning only to spot what is false also breeds distrust of accurate information. Solid for discernment, moderate for the risk of distrust
Citizens	Find out in advance, from reliable sources, how the vote is protected (*prebunking*).	Repeat that "disinformation threatens our elections", without explaining how the vote is protected.	It is the facts being explained that strengthen trust, whereas a warning about the threat has no effect on its own. In all cases, the effect remains small and disappears unless it is repeated. Solid in experiments, moderate in real life
Citizens	When faced with a suspicious video, check who published it first and whether a reliable source has picked it up.	Spread general alerts such as "beware of *deepfakes*".	These alerts do not help people spot fake videos. They do, however, lead people to judge authentic videos to be fake. Moderate
Media	Give disinformation the space it actually occupies, and use the occasion to remind audiences how the vote is protected.	Alarmist coverage that amplifies an isolated case or dwells on it.	Alarmist articles increase support for restrictions on free speech and do not strengthen trust. Articles that explain the safeguards of the vote do strengthen it. Moderate

Media	Put a specific label (“disputed”) on specific content, and respond when a politician wrongly accuses the outlet.	Publish general warnings (“false information is circulating”), or stay silent in the face of attacks.	General warnings also make people doubt accurate information. An outlet that responds to an unfounded accusation strengthens its credibility. **Solid for labels, moderate for responding to attacks**
Media	Fact-check campaign statements, targeting moderate and curious audiences first.	Hope that fact-checking will win over people already convinced by a false claim.	Fact-checking corrects beliefs, but it does not change votes. It reaches few of the most exposed, since almost no readers of a dubious site read the corresponding fact-check. **Solid for the effect, weak for the reach**
Media	When faced with suspicious content, trace it back to its original source before reporting on it, without rebroadcasting the clip.	Rebroadcast the content to denounce it, before establishing where it comes from.	These practices follow from research on amplification, but they have not been evaluated as such. **Untested**
Institutions	Explain all the real safeguards of the vote in advance, through election officials from across the political spectrum.	Communicate late, and talk mainly about the threat.	In survey experiments, these explanations markedly strengthen trust, including among sceptics. In an actual campaign, run among 148,000 conservative voters in the Houston area, they changed almost nothing, apart from a slight rise in confidence in voting by mail. Turning to trusted local messengers is a plausible avenue, but it has not been tested. **Solid in experiments, weak in real life**
Institutions	Make specific, documented cases of interference public: who, what, on what scale, what response.	Engage in sweeping, alarmist talk about interference, or wrongly present a citizen mobilisation as a foreign operation.	When the public reads that interference has swayed the vote, it judges the result less legitimate. A message centred on the threat does not reassure, whereas one explaining how the vote is protected does. **Moderate**
Institutions	After the vote, audit the results transparently, then make it known that the audit has taken place.	Let doubts about the count take hold without responding.	Telling voters that an audit has taken place strengthens their trust. How the audit is conducted and presented matters more than what it finds, as long as the discrepancies remain small. **Moderate**
Institutions	Regulate account authenticity and transparency (who is speaking, who is paying).	Pass laws that give the state the power to say what is true.	The effects of such laws have never been measured, and they risk fuelling suspicions of censorship. In France, for example, a 2018 law allows a judge, in the three months before a national election, to order on an urgent basis an end to the massive, artificial dissemination of a manifestly inaccurate allegation (the so-called electoral injunction). To our knowledge, this procedure has been used only once, without success. **Weak**

A LIMITATION: THE CANDIDATES' DILEMMA

These recommendations nevertheless have a limitation that must be faced squarely. Accepting the result, contesting it only with evidence, not invoking interference in general terms: all of this assumes actors acting in good faith, capable of a restraint that is hard to sustain in the heat of a campaign. Electoral integrity is a common good, and preserving it poses a collective action problem akin to the prisoner's dilemma. All candidates have an interest in keeping trust in the vote intact, but each of them, acting alone, may be tempted to break ranks by crying interference to discredit an opponent, by posing as a victim or by laying the groundwork in advance for a challenge in case of defeat. The gain is immediate and personal, while the cost is deferred and shared. In the case of contested results, as we have seen, part of that cost falls on the challenger, but it is too remote and too diffuse to weigh much in campaign calculations. If everyone reasons this way, trust collapses for everyone, the winner included.

	Candidate B shows restraint	**Candidate B cries interference**
Candidate A shows restraint	Trust in the vote is preserved. Good for everyone.	B gains a short-term advantage, and A looks naive.
Candidate A cries interference	A gains a short-term advantage, and B looks naive.	Trust collapses. Bad for everyone, the winner included.

Simplified diagram, for illustration only

Good practices will therefore not be enough if they remain individual. What is needed is a form of collective campaign discipline, which can take the shape of joint commitments by the parties, the refereeing role of independent authorities and the vigilance of the media. The media bear a particular responsibility here, since it falls to them to expose the contradiction, even the hypocrisy, of those who denounce foreign interference with rhetoric that in practice serves the aims of that very interference. This vigilance should apply to candidates and governments alike, since governments too can benefit from dramatising the threat.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

In the face of election disinformation, restraint often protects better than alarm. Restraint is not inaction: it means responding to specific cases, correcting specific content and explaining what protects the vote. Even the best tools, however, have only modest effects, which disappear when the message does not reach the people it is meant for, so that how widely the message travels and how credible the messenger is matter as much as what it says. The whole challenge, then, is to reach distrustful audiences through messengers they trust. Three directions follow for any country preparing for an election, which we illustrate with the example of France as the 2027 presidential election approaches:

- **A quieter state response, not a louder one.** In countries where trust in institutions is low, such as France, the state will probably do more good by supporting local, credible messengers (newsrooms, fact-checkers, local elected officials) than by issuing corrections itself, because those who distrust it are liable to read its corrections as positions rather than as facts. This is what research on source credibility suggests, as does the weak real-world effect of information campaigns on distrustful voters.

- **Make the most of the safeguards of one's own electoral procedure.** When a country has a robust procedure, its safeguards are the best argument against rumours of fraud, provided they are presented as guarantees of quality and this is done before the attacks come. In France, for example, voting is by paper ballot, and the count is manual and public: any citizen can attend, and every candidate can send representatives. These safeguards have the advantage of being simple to understand and easy to show, which makes them an asset to explain rather than a vulnerability to defend.
- **Evaluate what is put in place.** Each election is an opportunity to measure, under real conditions, the effect of the measures deployed, rather than renewing them without knowing whether they work. In France, the 2027 campaign will provide that opportunity, and missing it would mean basing another decade of electoral policy on survey-based findings that have never been confirmed in the field.

Finally, a campaign is not the moment when trust is built. Rather, it reveals within a few weeks the trust that has accumulated between elections, thanks to strong institutions, integrity in public life and independent journalism. The defence of an election is therefore prepared long before the vote, at a time when it seems to count for nothing.

Main sources: Gaudette et al., *BJPolS*, 2025 · Lockhart et al., *PNAS Nexus*, 2024 · Carey et al., *Science Advances*, 2025 · Kousser et al., *Science Advances*, 2026 · Bordeleau and Garnett, 2024 · Clayton et al., *Political Behavior*, 2020 · Neo, 2022 · Nyhan et al., 2020 · Guess, Nyhan and Reifler, 2020 · Jaffe et al., 2023 · La Croix-Verian, 2026 · G. Darcy, "Resisting disinformation in election season", *Futuribles*, forthcoming.

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